

**Workers Without Work:
Pigeons and the Infrastructural Afterlife of Domestication**

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Abstract

The end of a useful function leaves the lives organized around it unfinished. Pigeons make this mismatch unusually visible: their capacities for homing, reproduction and life near people survived the decline of many institutions that had employed them. This paper follows the withdrawal of those institutions through histories of pigeon keeping, disposal records, animal retirement statutes and urban control literature. It calls their uneven retreat *distributed decommissioning*. Comparisons with horses, military dogs and research chimpanzees distinguish the power to dispose of a worker from the acceptance of responsibility after work. Sale, adoption, sanctuary and protection of un-owned populations offer different settlements; none can be inferred from the disappearance of a task alone. The pigeon case also shows how a capacity once valued as a service can become an objection to its bearer's continued presence. Ecology and material harms matter to this process, but neither population counts nor control costs settle the question of obligation. The argument turns on the difference between arranging another use for an animal and recognizing a claim that no longer depends on its usefulness.

After the guidance program

When Project Pigeon lost its funding, B. F. Skinner had equipment to scrap and birds to keep. Thirty pigeons were retained to test how long their trained responses would last. Six years later, he reported, a bird could still respond correctly to its former target (Skinner 1960, 34, 36).

The program had ended before the competence it produced. Its birds still needed feeding the next morning. Skinner found a further use for them: measuring the persistence of a skill that the original project no longer required. This arrangement kept care within the terms of an experiment. It left open what would be owed when there was no further experiment to perform.

Street pigeons present a less orderly version of that question. Their domestic ancestry connects them to lofts, agricultural estates, message services and households whose purposes changed at different times. No single authority closed these arrangements, and some forms of pigeon keeping continue. The historical problem is what happens when a working relationship loses its purpose without acquiring an agreed ending for those whose lives it organized.

Pigeons make this problem visible because they can live beyond the organization that employed them. Their survival depends on food, nesting sites and their own capacities, not simply on the loss of a job. Discarded machinery can also create lasting obligations: a reactor or an oil well does not become harmless when production stops. Here, though, the remainder has interests of its own. It continues to suffer or flourish, and its descendants occupy places in which no institution has arranged for them to belong.

What a function holds together

A pigeon post required much more than a bird capable of finding its way home. It needed lofts, breeding, handlers, transport away from home and a route along which a return flight could carry information. Reuter's contract with Heinrich Geller in April 1850 divided these responsibilities in

writing. Geller was to supply and dispatch trained pigeons for the Brussels–Aachen route; Reuter bore the transport costs. The supplier was released from replacing birds lost on the journey. The initial term was three months, unless Reuter’s enterprise ended sooner (Reuter and Geller 1850, secs. 1–3, 7–10). The contract gave the service an end date. It made no corresponding promise of retirement. Its silence on the birds’ later care is a limit of the record, not proof that they were abandoned.

Other arrangements made different capacities valuable. In the pigeon towers near Isfahan, manure collection joined birds, nesting structures and an agricultural market. Ownership attached the birds and their product to a landlord (Beazley 1966). A dropping had a destination and a buyer. Its later appearance as damage to a city building would depend partly on the loss of that arrangement of collection and use.

The working animal belonged to an organization of places and expectations. Barua’s account of non-human life as infrastructure helps describe how animal capacities become parts of a larger operation (Barua 2021). Coulter’s account of animal work places the worker’s well-being within the discussion (Coulter 2016). Once that question is admitted, the end of a service cannot be assessed only through the savings or improved performance of its replacement.

Nor did relationships with pigeons disappear wherever a commercial use declined. Jerolmack’s ethnography of New York rooftop flyers describes how birds organized neighbourhood knowledge, competitive status and social ties across ethnic divisions (Jerolmack 2009). Affection and inherited practices could sustain a loft that no message business needed. Edgerton’s account of technologies that persist, disappear and reappear on different schedules helps resist a single chronology of replacement (Edgerton 2007).

Distributed decommissioning names the withdrawal of working arrangements by different actors, on different schedules, without a common settlement for the animals left outside them. Closures and neglect coexist with continuing forms of keeping, from which birds may also escape. Genetic work connects feral populations with domestic breeds, including racing pigeons (Stringham et al. 2012). It cannot reconstruct the founders of an arbitrary city flock. The historical records identify routes out of institutional care; they do not establish a single descent from a dismantled service to every bird on a street.

This unevenness matters to the allocation of responsibility. Each closure can look complete from the position of the organization making it. Taken together, the decisions leave a population that no one of those organizations counts as its remaining business.

When custody ends

The United States Army could close its pigeon service because its birds belonged to an identifiable organization. When the Fort Monmouth lofts closed in 1957, surviving veterans went to zoos or collections and roughly 1,000 other birds were sold. The sale took place on 23 March (National Agricultural Library, n.d.). The inventory could be cleared by transferring custody. That record

tells us where the Army's responsibility was taken to end, but not whether the birds' subsequent lives went well.

Urban horses passed through a longer chain of employers as their capacities declined. Rendering gave even a dead horse an economic value. McShane and Tarr's account includes a St. Louis firm's 1896 claim of a \$24 profit per carcass (McShane and Tarr 2007, 27–28). A sequence of remaining uses supplied a route to disposal. It did not require a settlement in which an animal's needs survived its exchange value.

The difference from pigeons cannot be explained by ownership alone. Horses had different feeding costs, reproductive patterns and requirements for urban space. Their absence from large feral populations in those cities is no controlled test of an institutional theory. What the comparison does expose is the distance between having the power to dispose of an animal and accepting a duty to care for it after work.

Retirement statutes make that distance unusually explicit. The United States military-dog law enacted in 2000 authorized adoption, subject to a suitability decision by the unit commander informed by veterinary advice. Adoption was not promised to every dog, and the law excluded federal liability for the adopted dog's later veterinary expenses (Military Working Dog Adoption Act 2000, § 1). It provided a way to move care to a new keeper.

The CHIMP Act made a different arrangement for designated surplus research chimpanzees: a sanctuary system with a duty of lifetime care. Its original provisions prohibited discharge from the system while permitting limited research and euthanasia in the animal's interests (CHIMP Act 2000, § 2). A continuing institutional obligation could thus be separated from an animal's remaining value to a particular project.

Ownership is not a prerequisite for every such obligation. The 1971 Wild Free-Roaming Horses and Burros Act defined a protected population of unbranded and unclaimed animals on federal public lands. The statute also provided for management, including removal and, under specified conditions, destruction (Wild Free-Roaming Horses and Burros Act 1971, §§ 1–3). Protection did not assure the survival of every animal. It assigned public duties toward an unowned population and required conflicts to be addressed within that responsibility.

These settlements distribute risks differently. An adoption can fail; an institution can underfund care; a population-level duty can permit severe intervention against individuals. Even so, the distinction survives those failures. Ending work, transferring custody and ending obligation are separate decisions. Technological replacement settles none of them automatically.

Becoming a problem

The control literature offers a view of the animal after its capacities have ceased to count as contributions. Williams and Corrigan's 1994 handbook entry warns that relocated pigeons may return from more than 50 miles away or create a problem elsewhere (Williams and Corrigan 1994, E–95).

A keeper's reliable return has become a building manager's failed removal. The bird need not lose its competence to lose the place that competence once secured.

This reversal is neither universal nor purely verbal. A racing pigeon can foul a neighbour's roof. An unowned flock can have devoted carers. Different valuations coexist; the practical question is whose valuation authorizes a decision about the birds. Jerolmack's history of New York reporting traces a shift from complaints about birds in particular locations to a broader category of the pigeon as a troublesome urban animal, with public-health claims forming part of its justification (Jerolmack 2008). A history of work and custody helps explain what that category leaves out. It cannot, by itself, explain the timing of a campaign or the difference between cities.

The harms still require attention. New York City's health guidance distinguishes ordinary encounters from dust exposure during cleaning and identifies particular concern for people with compromised immune systems (New York City Department of Health and Mental Hygiene, n.d.). Recognizing those hazards leaves room to ask which responses are proportionate, and whether the needs of the animals enter the decision at all.

The accounting of nuisance can obscure the same question. Pimentel and colleagues' estimate of \$1.1 billion in annual United States pigeon damage used an assumed density and an estimated control cost of \$9 per bird per year. Potential control expenditure served as a proxy for losses (Pimentel et al. 2000, 56). The estimate was not a national survey of realized damage. Money spent preventing a presence can differ substantially from the harm that presence causes. Once a population appears only as a cost of removal, the decision to remove it can seem to have been made by the accounting.

Ecology sets another limit on the institutional account. In Barcelona, an intervention combining public education with culling was associated with a 40% fall in pigeon density in two districts between February and June, without a corresponding change in the comparison district. Analyses within one district linked the decline more closely to reduced food availability than to culling effort (Senar et al. 2017). The treatments were not isolated by random assignment, and movement between areas remained a possible explanation for some change. Nevertheless, food availability plainly belongs in an account of persistence. Recognizing an obligation toward a population does not exempt its management from these material questions.

Remaining in place

A station canopy shelters passengers and, above them, may shelter nesting birds. Star's account of infrastructure emphasizes how its character depends on the position of its users: what enables one activity may obstruct another (Star 1999). Pigeons occupy parts of buildings whose assigned purpose makes no provision for their residence.

This gives the history of their work a spatial afterlife. Animals once incorporated into a communications network can also inhabit infrastructure whose managers want them absent. Barua describes this repurposing as part of the relationship between infrastructure and non-human life

(Barua 2021). It is not necessary for every bird on a station roof to descend from a message carrier for the conflict to arise.

Feral nonspace names a site that supports animal habitation while its managers treat that habitation as unauthorized. Nets, spikes and altered ledges are the material work of enforcing that judgment. They change where birds can settle; they cannot make the need for a place to settle disappear. Philo and Wilbert's distinction between places allotted to animals and places animals make for themselves helps keep both uses in view (Philo and Wilbert 2000).

Some sites require exclusion. A hospital ventilation shaft and an unused industrial roof pose different questions. Yet moving birds from one building to another can leave the question of their residence unanswered at the scale of the city. An owner may have dealt with a complaint while no authority has decided where the excluded population can live.

After usefulness

A history of employment might support a claim of repayment: care owed for services rendered. For city pigeons that argument soon meets a difficulty. Many have never performed a task for a keeper, and their particular ancestry cannot be recovered. A claim that depends on proving former service would leave much of the population outside it.

Donaldson and Kymlicka's account of liminal animals offers another starting point. Their idea of denizenship recognizes animals living among people without being owned by them: residents owed protections, though not full members of a shared citizenship (Donaldson and Kymlicka 2011, ch. 7). Residence and an ongoing relationship can ground claims that an account of productive contribution misses.

The ethical premise taken up here is that lives shaped around an institution's purposes cannot become irrelevant to its decisions merely because those purposes change. Where the original institution has disappeared, present relationships, capacity to act and the interests of those affected must inform the allocation of responsibility. Historical involvement gives a reason to ask who should act; it cannot specify a budget or confer a right to every ledge. Membership, in this limited sense, means a standing claim to consideration in decisions about a shared place. Particular uses of that place remain open to dispute.

A managed loft is one possible way to make such a claim administratively visible. It gives care an address and someone the task of carrying it out. That attraction is not evidence of effectiveness. Giunchi and colleagues' 2012 review reported a lack of quantitative evidence for the population-control efficacy of urban dovecotes with egg replacement (Giunchi et al. 2012). Any present proposal would need to assess welfare, movement and displaced conflict as well as numbers. The institutional question precedes the choice of this or any other device: does the population enter the decision as a subject of care, or only as a presence to be reduced?

Finding the birds another use would answer a different question. Skinner could retain them for a new experiment; a fancier could value their performance. Such arrangements can sustain care,

but make it depend on another demand. A continuing claim would matter precisely when no replacement task could be found. Accepting it would change the terms on which the relationship ended.

Pigeons did not disappear when their work did. They remained embodied, reproductive and present in places that no longer assigned them a purpose. Their history reveals a problem larger than the history of domestication: technological systems can abolish a function more quickly than societies can determine what is owed to those who once performed it. Usefulness can end before membership does.

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